

# Remote Onboarding Audit Checklist

Companion to *Onboarding for Distributed Software Teams: The First 30 Days* — a diagnostic tool for L&D designers and engineering managers.

## How to use this checklist

Score your current onboarding program against the five framework moves from the module. For each item, mark Yes (your program reliably does this), Partial (sometimes, or in spirit but not consistently), or No (your program does not do this, or does the opposite).

A program that scores fully Yes is rare. A program that scores No or Partial on more than half the items is almost certainly remote-translated rather than remote-native — exactly the failure mode the module describes. The point of the checklist is not the score. The point is the conversations the score starts.

## Section 1 — The framing question

Before scoring the specifics, answer this one:

**Was your current onboarding program designed for remote work, or designed for in-person work and adapted?**

- ☐ Designed remote-native from the start
- ☐ Designed in-person, then adapted when the team went remote
- ☐ Mixed — some elements remote-native, others adapted
- ☐ Honestly, I don't know

*If your answer is anything other than 'designed remote-native from the start,' the rest of this checklist will surface where the in-person scaffolding is still load-bearing.*

## Section 2 — Day 1: Access Over Activity

| Yes                      | Partial                  | No                       |                                                                                                                                                        |
|--------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | The new engineer's repository access is verified working before Day 1, not configured during Day 1.                                                    |
| <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | The new engineer's local development environment was tested by a senior engineer the week before the start date.                                       |
| <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | The new engineer has deploy permissions to staging on Day 1.                                                                                           |
| <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | The new engineer is added to a small number of named primary Slack/Teams channels, with optional channels labeled as such.                             |
| <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | A single named documentation entry point exists, and links from there to no more than three required first-week reads.                                 |
| <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | The new engineer's Day 1 schedule terminates in a concrete shipped artifact (small PR, first commit, deploy to staging) — not in a series of meetings. |
| <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | Day 1 contains fewer than three hours of scheduled meetings.                                                                                           |

### Score read:

**6–7 Yes** — Day 1 is access-focused. This is rare. Continue.

**3–5 Yes** — Day 1 has the right intent but is leaking activity. Identify the two items most easily fixed.

**0–2 Yes** — Day 1 is activity-focused, regardless of how it feels from the manager's side.

## Section 3 — Week 1: Designed Connections

| Yes                      | Partial                  | No                       |                                                                                                                    |
|--------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | The new engineer's Week 1 has 4-5 scheduled introductory meetings, not 10+.                                        |
| <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | Each Week 1 meeting is tied to specific work the new engineer will do (not generic 'get to know each other').      |
| <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | Each Week 1 meeting has a concrete agenda beyond introductions.                                                    |
| <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | The connections are scheduled by the manager, not left to the new engineer to organize.                            |
| <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | At least one Week 1 meeting involves shared work (pairing, design review, code walkthrough), not just shared time. |
| <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | There is a built-in reason for follow-up between the new engineer and each connection within the next two weeks.   |

**Score read:**

**5-6 Yes** — Connections are designed. Verify with the new engineer at Day 14 — do they have working relationships, or just introductions?

**2-4 Yes** — Connection plan has the right shape but is still leaking randomness. Most common failure: meetings tied to 'upcoming projects' in framing but not in actual shared work.

**0-1 Yes** — Random virtual coffee chats by another name. Rebuild the Week 1 connection plan from scratch using the four criteria.

## Section 4 — Weeks 2-3: Productive Confusion

| Yes                      | Partial                  | No                       |                                                                                                                                      |
|--------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | The new engineer's Week 2 ticket is real work the team needs, not a made-up onboarding project.                                      |
| <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | A specific senior engineer is assigned as the primary code reviewer for the new engineer's first month.                              |
| <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | The senior engineer is briefed on the discipline of letting the new engineer struggle productively (not solving for them).           |
| <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | The new engineer has explicit permission and a named release valve for asking for help when stuck.                                   |
| <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | The team treats searching, asking questions, and exploratory PRs as visible signs of learning, not as signs of weakness.             |
| <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | The first ticket has a calibrated timebox — challenging enough to require real work, bounded enough to prevent indefinite stuckness. |

### Score read:

**5-6 Yes** — Productive confusion is supported. The most common gap is item 3 — managers know to assign a code reviewer but don't brief them on the discipline.

**2-4 Yes** — The structure is partially in place but the senior engineer's role is undertrained. Address this first.

**0-1 Yes** — New engineers are either being rescued too fast or left to drift. Both produce the same downstream problem.

## Section 5 — Day 30: The Quiet Failure Point

| Yes                      | Partial                  | No                       |                                                                                                                                                   |
|--------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | A Day 30 check-in is scheduled and held for every new engineer.                                                                                   |
| <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | The check-in is structured around specific behavioral observations (PR volume, channel presence, standup patterns), not around 'how is it going.' |
| <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | The manager reviews the new engineer's PR trends, question patterns, and channel activity before the check-in.                                    |
| <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | The manager treats absence-from-team-channels as a stronger signal than reduced PR volume.                                                        |
| <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | The manager has a clear plan for what to do if the check-in surfaces real disengagement signals.                                                  |
| <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> | The Day 30 check-in is treated as a high-leverage management moment, not a calendar formality.                                                    |

### Score read:

**5-6 Yes** — Day 30 is being used as the leverage point it is. Verify the check-in actually surfaces signals — if every check-in produces 'everything is fine,' the structure is right but the conversation is not.

**2-4 Yes** — The check-in exists but is not yet structured. Most common: the manager holds the meeting but does not review behavioral data beforehand.

**0-1 Yes** — Day 30 is being missed entirely or treated as a generic 1:1. This is the highest-leverage gap to close.

## Scoring overall

Count your total Yes answers across all 25 items:

|                  |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>20–25 Yes</b> | Your program is meaningfully remote-native. Use the gaps to drive incremental refinement, and consider whether your program is a model worth documenting publicly.                                                                                             |
| <b>12–19 Yes</b> | Your program has the right intent in most places but is still leaking translation. Pick the two lowest-scoring sections and identify one specific change in each within the next 30 days.                                                                      |
| <b>6–11 Yes</b>  | Your program is mostly remote-translated. The audit's most useful output here is identifying which one section to redesign first. Section 2 (Day 1) is usually the highest-leverage starting point because it sets the foundation for everything that follows. |
| <b>0–5 Yes</b>   | Your program needs a redesign, not a refinement. Run this checklist with one or two trusted colleagues before scoping the redesign — multiple perspectives surface gaps that any single perspective misses.                                                    |

## What to do with the results

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Pick two items, not ten. The audit is most useful when it focuses your next 30 days, not when it overwhelms you with everything that could be better.

Pick items where you have authority, not items that require organizational change you can't drive. Verifying repo access pre-Day-1 is something a manager can fix unilaterally. Limiting Day 1 meetings might require negotiating with HR or executive leadership about company-wide orientation policies. Start with the items inside your control.

Track one specific change per item. 'Improve our access checklist' is a wish. 'Add a senior-engineer dry-run of the dev environment setup the week before each new hire's start date' is a change.

Re-run the checklist in 90 days. The point is not to score perfectly. The point is to see your program move from one section to the next over time.